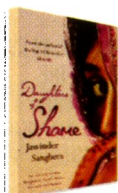


The Invisible Victims

A courageous account of the atrocities South Asian women suffer in a foreign land

[By Urvashi Butalia]



DAUGHTERS OF SHAME

by JASVINDER SANGHERA

Hachette India

Price: Rs 295

Pages: 304

Jasvinder Sanghera's *Daughters of Shame* forms a fitting sequel to her first book, *Shame*, and marks the trajectory that so many battered women follow: from the personal to the political. In *Shame*, Sanghera detailed the painful story of her flight from her family, the escape from a coerced marriage into a relationship of choice, and the difficulties and complexities that followed. Life did not deal up easy victories to her.

Like Flavia Agnes's book *My Story, Our Story*, published by the author in Mumbai some 20 years ago, Sanghera also took the first frightening step of making her personal story public in *Shame*. Agnes, now a well-known lawyer, still feels vulnerable and exposed when she thinks of that book. No doubt Sanghera shares similar feelings—not uncommon when such histories emerge. The self-doubt and embarrassment that women feel at putting their lives on the line for public consumption often renders invisible the tremendous courage it takes for them to speak out.

In *Daughters of Shame*, Sanghera, now a confident, articulate woman, used to dealing with the police, with civic authorities, with bureaucracy and with families, has set up a centre called Karma Nirvana. Here, she and her colleagues, who like her, have been through tough family experiences, provide advice, counselling, active help and sometimes just a shoulder to cry on, an

ear to listen, both so important in the silent world of violence that so many women inhabit.

As story after story pours out, you hear the same things: parents pushing young women into marriages they do not want, locking them up inside homes, killing them and packing their bodies into suitcases, the police being sometimes complicit and sometimes helpful, and the terrible, terrible desolation and aloneness of being the victim of such violence, with, in most cases, no real escape.

And as Sanghera tells us despairingly, all of this is happening in multi-cultural Britain, in South Asian communities for whom, predictably, preserving their "culture" and their "traditions"—so important to migrant communities—generally take two forms: an almost fundamentalist allegiance to religion, and violence towards their women.

As much as Karma Nirvana emerges as a haven for battered South Asian women in Britain, so also *Daughters of Shame* recounts a history of South Asian communities that is different from the narrative of success and achievement, and different from the earlier dominating narrative of racism. This is a history from within, and all the more honest for that, for in a "foreign" land, to stand up and critique your own means to take on the opprobrium of somehow being "different", of being "disloyal" to the community. In the 20 years that have passed since Sanghera left her home and family, she has clearly resolved these questions in her mind, for you see none of the ambivalence and self-doubt in her that so characterised her story in the first book.

This isn't an earth-shaking book. Women's movements across the world have thrown up such histories, and in Britain itself Sanghera follows a tradition set by earlier writers such as Pratibha Parmar, Rahila Gupta, and indeed by women's groups like Southall Black Sisters. But it's a brave and necessary book for turning the spotlight on the community, for giving no quarter, and for looking beyond the individual experience to a wider, common and therefore more disturbing reality

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